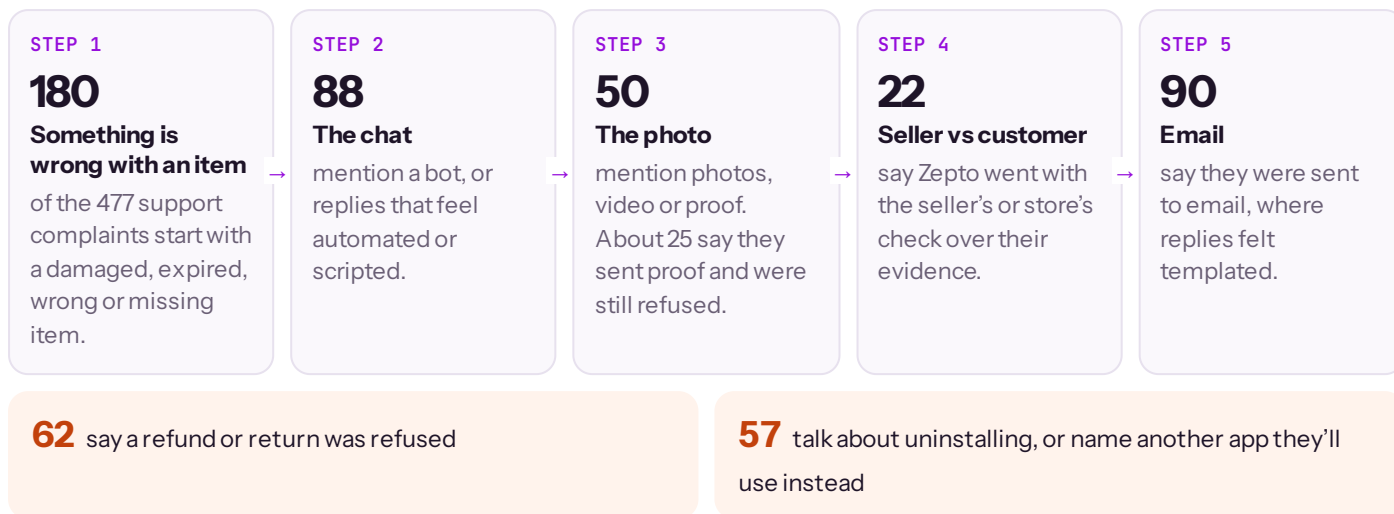


Where a small item problem turns into a lost customer

A closer read of the 477 support complaints in the deck: what happens step by step, and a spec that speeds up good customers without opening the door to refund abuse.

01 The path, as customers describe it

477 OF 1,026 SPECIFIC COMPLAINTS MENTION SUPPORT · COUNTS BELOW ARE OUT OF THOSE 477



02 What stands out

- **The photo step already exists.** The break comes after it: an automated “no”, then email. Customers don’t object to showing proof; they object to proof not changing the answer.
- **The amounts are small.** Where reviewers name the value in dispute it is mostly a few hundred rupees or less: ₹35, ₹44, ₹59, ₹70, ₹200, ₹225, ₹480.
- **Long-time customers get the same treatment as new ones.** Several mention years of orders or a membership, and are handled like any first-time claim.
- **Tighter refunds are a fair response to abuse.** The cost just shows up somewhere else: in churn among good customers. The fix below keeps the controls and changes who they apply to.

“Shared video, invoice and proof of re-ordering elsewhere, but support ... sent the same copy-paste AI automated mails ‘images show item intact’ reply 10+ times.”

1★ · 24 Sep 2026 · refunded only after a National Consumer Helpline complaint

“I’ve been a loyal customer since 2022 and have placed hundreds of orders. Earlier, genuine issues were handled quickly with refunds.”

1★ · 11 Sep 2026

“Zepto claims the seller checked the product and it was fresh at dispatch, but when I asked them to provide dispatch photos/proof, they did not provide any. This is not about the ₹59 refund.”

1★ · 17 Sep 2026

“It forces you to provide a photo for a refund, but then doesn’t allow you to submit it.”

1★ · 20 Sep 2026 · in-app camera freezing on Android

One decision rule, applied in the chat

SITUATION	WHAT HAPPENS
Trusted customer*, item under ₹X	Photo → instant refund or credit in the chat. No agent needed.
Trusted customer, item above ₹X	Photo → a person reviews in the same chat, target under 30 min.
New account, or high past claim rate	Photo → a person reviews. No automatic refund.
Photo check and store check disagree	Never an automatic “no”. A person decides, using the store’s dispatch photo if one exists.
Photo upload fails	Offer gallery upload or skip; the case goes to a person and the failure is logged.

*Trusted = for example 6+ months of orders and a claim rate below the city median. ₹X, 30 min and every threshold here are starting values to tune, not recommendations.

A Four product changes

- **Keep the case in the chat.** No email step; a visible status: received → with a person → resolved.
- **A person after two bot turns**, with the expected wait shown.
- **A tie-break rule** for store vs customer, starting with dairy, ice cream and fresh produce, which come up again and again in these reviews.
- **Photo upload that can’t trap people:** fallback options plus crash monitoring on the support camera.

B Abuse controls that stay

- Claim rate per customer, device and address, not only per account.
- Monthly cap on automatic refunds per customer; above it, a person decides.
- Random audit of a small share of automatic refunds.
- Automatic refunds pause for a store or category if claims spike.

C How I’d measure it

PRIMARY

Share of item issues resolved in the first chat, with no email

BUSINESS

Orders in the 30 days after an item issue, against the 30 days before

GUARDRAILS

Refund cost per 1,000 orders · share of automatic refunds later flagged as abuse · photo-upload failure rate

TEST

50/50 by customer in two cities for four weeks

D Events to log from day one

issue_reported (category, item value)

photo_upload_started / _failed

auto_decision (approve / reject / to_person)

bot_turns_before_person

email_redirect_shown

resolved (channel, minutes)

reopened_within_7d

E What I can’t see from outside

Zepto’s current refund rules and thresholds, how the photo check decides, the real abuse rate, and whether stores keep dispatch photos. Some of this may already be in place; I’d start by checking these four before building anything.